



▲ CUBAN MISSILE CRISIS

In 1961, the US tried to overthrow Cuba's communist government. In response, the USSR promised to defend Cuba by setting up missiles in the country. The US then tried to block Soviet ships (above), and sent planes to patrol the waters around Cuba. A nuclear war seemed inevitable, but the two sides reached a compromise and the USSR withdrew its missiles from the region.



▲ MCCARTHYISM

In the 1950s, many people in the US feared a communist uprising in the country. In reaction to this fear, a US Senator, Joseph McCarthy (above), began accusing some people, from government officials to Hollywood stars, of being secret communists or supporters of the USSR. His anticommunist campaign ruined the careers and lives of many.

FACT

Many countries in Asia and Africa did not want to support either of the two superpowers during the Cold War. They formed the Non-Aligned Movement in the 1960s.

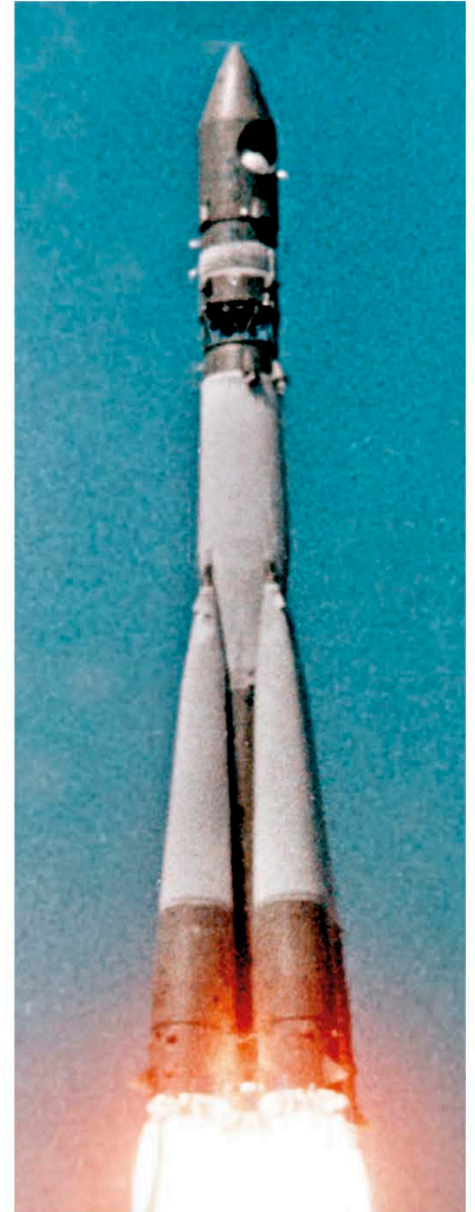
► THREAT OF NUCLEAR WAR

After the end of World War II, the US and USSR began to develop more powerful weapons. By the 1960s both countries had nuclear weapons, and people lived in fear of nuclear attack. Across the US, schools held drills teaching children to dive under desks and cover their heads to protect themselves in case of a nuclear explosion.



▼ SPACE RACE

The power struggle between the US and USSR was not limited to politics. Both superpowers also competed to develop technology that would make travel to space possible. In 1961, USSR's Yuri Gagarin became the first man to reach Earth's orbit on board the spacecraft Vostok 1 (below).



PROXY WARS

1950–1953

War breaks out in the Korean Peninsula as North Korea, supported by China and the USSR, and South Korea, aided by the US, battle to control the region.

1955–1975

Communist North Vietnam attacks South Vietnam. The conflict escalates when the US sends thousands of soldiers to hold back the communists.

1975

Civil war erupts in the African country of Angola. The US sends aid to the anticommunist party, while Cuba sends troops to support the communist fighters.

1979–1989

The USSR sends its army to support the communist government of Afghanistan against anticommunists, who were armed by the US.